INDEPENDENT STRATEGIC RESEARCH & CASE STUDY

BUSINESS MODEL ADAPTATION

A cross-industry strategy playbook for designing social media around how businesses actually acquire, convert, and retain customers.

STRATEGY / RESEARCH / EXECUTION / MEASUREMENT

BUSINESS / CASE
Cross-Industry Strategy Lab

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CROSS-INDUSTRY PLAYBOOK

THE CORE IDEA

The business model is the brief.

Social media strategy should follow the economics, customer decision process, and operating constraints of the business - not a generic posting template.

Do not begin with "What should we post?"
Begin with "What must the customer do next - and why would they?"

01

ECONOMICS

How the business earns: one-time purchase, subscription, service fee, recurring membership, or transaction commission.

02

DECISION

How customers decide: impulse, comparison, trust-building, stakeholder approval, trial, appointment, or community fit.

03

CONSTRAINT

What currently limits growth: weak discovery, poor qualification, conversion friction, low activation, retention, or fulfilment.

What this playbook delivers

- **A model-fit framework:** connect business mechanics to audience, content, conversion event, and KPI.
- **Five public-company benchmarks:** use official disclosures to understand business models, then derive cautious SMM implications.
- **An operating method:** diagnose one constraint, run a focused test, and measure movement in the business outcome.

Research boundary: company model facts come from public filings and official sources. The SMM recommendations are independent strategic interpretations, not claims about those companies' internal social media performance.

START HERE

Diagnose before you design.

Use the same questioning system for every client, but allow the answers - not your favorite platform - to shape the strategy.

THE 7-QUESTION STRATEGY FIT TEST

01 **Revenue logic**
What is being sold, and how does money arrive?

02 **Buyer & user**
Who pays, who uses, and who influences the decision?

03 **Decision risk**
What could the buyer lose by making the wrong choice?

04 **Sales cycle**
Does conversion happen in minutes, days, or months?

05 **Repeat behaviour**
One-time purchase, repeat purchase, renewal, or expansion?

06 **Conversion route**
Checkout, message, booking, demo, application, or sales call?

07 **Operating limit**
Inventory, capacity, onboarding, product activation, or follow-up?

STRATEGY FIT

Business model

Revenue + buying process + delivery model

DECISION JOURNEY

Need → evaluate → trust → act

STRATEGY DESIGN

Message → content → CTA → funnel

SUCCESS MEASURE

Qualified action → business outcome

THE KEY RULE

A strategy is not “model-fit” until it explains **which customer action matters, what blocks that action, and how the team will know if the block changed.**

MODEL COMPARISON

One funnel. Different critical events.

These are common starting patterns, not rigid rules. Validate them against the company's actual buying journey and unit economics.

BUSINESS MODEL	WHAT THE BUYER NEEDS	CONTENT JOB	NEXT ACTION	CORE OUTCOME
B2C e-commerce	Product fit, quality, price, delivery confidence	Show, compare, reassure	Product page / checkout	Profitable orders
Local service	Location fit, trust, availability	Explain service, prove credibility	Call / booking / visit	Attended appointments
B2B service	Expertise, credibility, business case	Educate, diagnose, demonstrate proof	Qualified discovery call	Won client / pipeline
SaaS	Use-case fit, workflow proof, usability	Demo, educate, reduce adoption risk	Trial / demo / activation	Activated retained users
Online education	Outcome fit, learning path, instructor trust	Teach, set expectations, answer objections	Enrol / attend session	Qualified enrolment
Membership	Ongoing value, belonging, participation	Show member experience and progress	Join / participate / renew	Retention / renewal
Marketplace	Selection, trust, transaction safety	Help both sides discover and transact	Buy / list / apply	Successful transactions

HOW TO USE THE MATRIX

- Choose the closest business model, then identify what is unusual about this specific company.
- Map the real customer journey. "Lead" or "conversion" must be defined rather than assumed.
- Select one primary business outcome, with supporting indicators for the earlier funnel stages.

Strategic warning: The closest-looking competitor may not be the best strategy benchmark if its revenue model, sales cycle, margins, or fulfilment capacity differs.

FAST CONVERSION JOURNEYS

E-commerce and local services.

Reduce the right kind of friction. An order and an attended appointment are not interchangeable conversion events.

01 / B2C E-COMMERCE

Make the product easier to choose.

AUDIENCE
Use cases, style/preferences, budget, buying triggers, product objections.

CONTENT
Demo in context; comparisons; FAQs; reviews; sizing or care guidance; shipping/returns clarity.

FUNNEL
Discovery → product evaluation → product page → cart → checkout → post-purchase.

CTA
Explore collection / Check size / View details / Shop now.

PRIMARY KPIs
Purchase conversion, CAC, AOV, contribution margin, return rate, repeat purchase.

Diagnose: if product views are healthy but purchases lag, inspect product-page clarity, stock, price/offer, trust and checkout before simply increasing posting volume.

02 / LOCAL SERVICE

Turn local relevance into attendance.

AUDIENCE
Service area, need urgency, trust criteria, opening hours, convenience.

CONTENT
Staff/service introduction; process walkthrough; FAQs; directions; verified reviews; availability.

FUNNEL
Local discovery → trust → call/message → booking → attendance → review/repeat.

CTA
Book an appointment / Call to check availability / Get directions.

PRIMARY KPIs
Qualified calls, completed bookings, attendance rate, cost per attended appointment, repeat visits.

Diagnose: booking volume can overstate real demand when no-shows are high. Track attended appointments and service capacity.

THE DIFFERENCE IN ONE LINE

E-commerce: reduce uncertainty around the product and transaction. **Local service:** reduce uncertainty around trust, location, booking and attendance.

COMPLEX PURCHASE JOURNEYS

B2B services and SaaS.

The content should help a buyer understand the problem, judge fit, reduce perceived risk, and take the next sensible step.

03 / B2B SERVICES

Sell the thinking, not just the deliverable.

BUYER
Owner or leader accountable for an operational or commercial problem.

PROOF
Clear methodology, relevant examples, documented outcomes, process transparency.

CONTENT
Problem breakdowns, frameworks, case analyses, audit findings, expert POV.

CTA
Request an audit / Book a discovery call / Discuss a use case.

KPI
Qualified pipeline, meetings held, opportunity conversion, win rate, CAC/payback.

04 / SAAS

Make value visible before asking for commitment.

BUYER / USER
Decision-maker, evaluator, implementer and day-to-day user may differ.

PROOF
Use-case demonstration, workflow walkthrough, integration clarity and realistic limitations.

CONTENT
Problem-solution demos, templates, use cases, implementation stories, comparison guides.

CTA
Start a trial / Book a demo / Explore a workflow.

KPI
Qualified sign-ups, activation, trial-to-paid, retention, churn and expansion.

CONTENT MUST MATCH THE BUYER'S QUESTION

AWARENESS	EVALUATION	VALIDATION	ACTION
What is the problem?	**Could this solution fit?**	**Can I trust the claim?**	**What happens next?**
Insight post / diagnostic checklist	Demo / framework / FAQ	Evidence / case study / constraints	Clear CTA / low-friction next step

Important: in a long sales cycle, social media may assist trust and evaluation without being the final conversion source. Connect marketing activity with CRM and sales outcomes wherever feasible.

BEYOND THE FIRST CONVERSION

Education, memberships and marketplaces.

These models need to earn a second decision: enrolment and learning, renewal and participation, or a successful two-sided transaction.

MODEL	CONTENT THAT REDUCES RISK	JOURNEY	MEASURE PAST THE CLICK
Online education	Teach something useful; clarify level, curriculum, instructor credibility, time commitment and realistic outcomes.	Useful lesson → programme fit → session/demo → enrolment → learner experience	Qualified enrolments, lead-to-enrolment, refunds, completion, continuation
Membership / subscription community	Show recurring value, member participation, event access, support, progress and culture.	Value preview → join → onboarding → participation → renewal	Activation, participation, renewal, churn, referrals
Marketplace / platform	Build buyer confidence and provider supply; explain quality standards, transaction steps and protection.	Discover → evaluate options → contact/transact → review; separate provider journey	Active buyers and sellers, inquiry-to-transaction, repeat transactions, fulfilment quality

WHAT CHANGES BY MODEL?

EDUCATION

LEARNING

Promise a credible learning experience; avoid inflated outcome claims.

MEMBERSHIP

RENEWAL

The first sale is not the finish line. Prove continuing value and support onboarding.

MARKETPLACE

TWO SIDES

Acquiring buyers without enough quality supply - or sellers without demand - can leave the marketplace unbalanced.

STRATEGIC CHECK

For recurring models, include post-purchase communication and experience design in the SMM plan. For marketplaces, deliberately identify which side of the market is currently constrained.

EVIDENCE-LED BENCHMARKS

Read the business model before borrowing the marketing playbook.

Public disclosures clarify business mechanics. The social media implications below are our strategic interpretations - not disclosures of internal campaign performance.

01 / SHOPIFY [1]

A platform with subscription and merchant-success revenue.

Its 2025 Form 10-K describes two principal revenue components: subscription solutions and merchant solutions. The latter includes services such as payments, shipping-related offerings and other merchant tools. Shopify's disclosures also describe plans that serve merchants at different stages of scale. [1]

SMM implication: content can segment by merchant maturity and solve specific growth/operations problems - not only promote platform features.

02 / ETSY [2]

A marketplace that connects buyers and sellers.

Etsy's 2025 disclosures describe revenue from marketplace activities including transaction fees, payment processing and listing fees, alongside optional seller services. Its investor materials identify discovery, unique goods, and buyer-seller connections as important elements of its marketplace proposition. [2]

SMM implication: a platform strategy should support both demand (buyers) and supply (sellers), while reinforcing discovery and transaction trust.

WHAT NOT TO ASSUME

- A disclosed revenue model does not prove which social platform or content format performs best.
- A strategic recommendation is a hypothesis until validated against audience and campaign evidence.
- A company's size, resources and brand equity may make its playbook unsuitable for a smaller client.

DIFFERENT ECONOMICS, DIFFERENT CONTENT QUESTIONS

SaaS, education, and recurring membership.

A business can sell software access, education, or a physical-world membership. The commercial action and retention mechanism are different.

03 / SALESFORCE [3]

Subscription-led enterprise software

Public disclosure: Salesforce reported FY2026 total revenue of $41.5B, including $39.4B in subscription and support revenue. [3]

Strategic interpretation: Content hypothesis: focus on complex business problems, workflows, integrations, governance, use cases and stakeholder-specific proof. Evaluate qualified opportunities, not only attention.

04 / COURSERA [4]

Consumer + enterprise learning

Public disclosure: Coursera's FY2025 filing describes both consumer revenue and enterprise revenue; subscription products and direct learning purchases are part of its model. [4]

Strategic interpretation: Content hypothesis: combine learner-facing teaching and programme-fit content with enterprise-facing proof about workforce skills, deployment and organisational value. Separate the journeys.

05 / PLANET FITNESS [5]

Recurring membership + franchise model

Public disclosure: Planet Fitness' 2025 filing describes predictable recurring revenue streams, including monthly dues, royalties and annual fees; over 90% of corporate-owned club and franchise revenue consisted of recurring revenue streams. [5]

Strategic interpretation: Content hypothesis: show ease of joining, member experience, accessible routines, local club relevance and ongoing reasons to participate. Track joins alongside attendance, engagement and renewal signals.

Evidence discipline: These are business-model facts and strategist-generated hypotheses. No company's private social results, content calendar, or causal lift is claimed.

MEASURE THE CUSTOMER ACTION THAT MATTERS

A KPI system should mirror the business model.

Use leading indicators to diagnose movement through the journey, but judge performance with an outcome close to the business goal.

MODEL	LEADING INDICATORS	PRIMARY OUTCOME	QUALITY / GUARDRAIL
E-commerce	Qualified product views, add-to-cart, checkout start	Purchases, CAC, contribution margin	Returns, discount dependence, AOV
Local service	Local reach, calls, booking starts	Attended appointments, cost per attendance	No-shows, capacity, repeat visits
B2B service	Relevant engagement, qualified form fills, meetings	Qualified pipeline, won clients, payback	Lead relevance, sales velocity, margin
SaaS	Target-account traffic, sign-ups, feature use	Activation, paid conversion, retained users	Churn, support burden, acquisition cost
Education	Course-outline views, session registrations, qualified leads	Qualified enrolment, course revenue	Refunds, fit, completion / satisfaction
Membership	Trial/join interest, onboarding activity	Renewal, active participation, retention	Churn reasons, experience quality
Marketplace	Search/listing views, enquiries, supply onboarding	Successful transactions, repeat use	Trust incidents, quality supply, fulfilment

A SIMPLE DECISION RULE

01

Locate the leak

Which journey stage is underperforming relative to a sensible baseline?

02

Find the why

Use audience evidence, messages, objections, site/CRM data and operational context.

03

Run a test

Change one meaningful variable, define the window, then review quality and outcome.

METRIC HYGIENE

Define the KPI in plain language; record source, attribution limits, conversion window, baseline and owner. Separate correlation from causation. Revenue attributed to a campaign is not automatically incremental revenue or profit.

FROM UNKNOWNS TO AN EVIDENCE-BASED PLAN

A practical 30-day adaptation sprint.

This roadmap assumes an early-stage client with limited historical data. Reorder it when urgent operational, compliance, or tracking gaps require attention first.

DAYS 01-05

DISCOVER

Business model & constraints

Confirm offer, pricing, margin, customer types, sales route, delivery capacity and current customer journey. Audit social profiles, website/landing pages, sales handoff, existing analytics and available creative.

OUTPUT: business-model brief + unknowns register

DAYS 06-12

RESEARCH

Audience & decision evidence

Review customer interviews, comments, reviews, enquiries, lost leads, sales notes and competitor positioning. Segment by need, urgency, fit and buying role. Distinguish evidence from assumptions.

OUTPUT: audience hypotheses + message map

DAYS 13-20

DESIGN & TEST

One bottleneck, a small test

Choose one priority stage and one hypothesis. Create a controlled set of messages/creative, a fit-for-purpose CTA, a destination that removes friction, and a measurement plan.

OUTPUT: test brief + tracking checklist

DAYS 21-30

LEARN

Decision, not vanity report

Review outcome and leading metrics, lead/customer quality, qualitative feedback, cost, operational constraints and measurement limitations. Keep, revise, or stop the approach based on evidence.

OUTPUT: decision log + next 30-day plan

Deliverable standard: Every recommendation must name the business problem, evidence, expected action, KPI, owner and review date.

WORKED DIAGNOSIS

When “more content” is not the answer.

Illustrative scenario - not real company performance. Use the logic to practice how a strategist separates symptoms from constraints.

THE SYMPTOM

A SaaS business has rising social reach and many trial sign-ups, but few users activate the core workflow. Sales says many sign-ups are poor-fit users.

STRATEGIST RESPONSE

01 / CLARIFY

Define activation precisely. What meaningful product action predicts genuine value?

02 / SEGMENT

Compare activated vs non-activated users by source, role, business type, stated need and use case.

03 / DIAGNOSE

Test fit problem vs onboarding friction vs unclear value proposition vs product usability.

04 / ACT

Adjust audience/message if lead fit is poor; improve onboarding/demo if the right users get stuck.

EVIDENCE TO COLLECT BEFORE SCALING

- **Source-to-activation analysis:** which channels and creative themes bring users who activate?
- **Qualitative evidence:** short interviews, onboarding feedback, support tickets and session recordings where consent/legal requirements permit.
- **Funnel integrity:** events are defined consistently and tracked with usable attribution caveats.
- **Economics:** activated user cost, trial-to-paid conversion, retention and the cost of supporting poor-fit users.

Decision: do not scale spend only because reach and sign-ups are increasing. First determine whether the bottleneck is audience fit, message, onboarding, product value or measurement quality.

REFERENCE NOTES

Public disclosures + independent strategic inference.

Source refresh: 10 October 2026. Links below point to primary-company or regulatory filings where available.

[1] Shopify Inc.

2025 Form 10-K / annual filing. Describes Subscription Solutions and Merchant Solutions as principal revenue components; merchant services extend platform functionality.

https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/1594805/000159480526000007/shop-20251231.htm

[2] Etsy, Inc.

2025 Form 10-K. Describes marketplace revenue streams, including transaction fees, payment processing, listing fees and optional seller services.

https://investors.etsy.com/sec-filings/all-sec-filings/content/0001370637-26-000019/etsy-20251231.htm

[3] Salesforce, Inc.

FY2026 results announcement. Reports fiscal 2026 total revenue of $41.5B and subscription & support revenue of $39.4B.

https://investor.salesforce.com/news/news-details/2026/Salesforce-Delivers-Record-Fourth-Quarter-Fiscal-2026-Results/default.aspx

[4] Coursera, Inc.

2025 Form 10-K. Describes consumer and enterprise revenue, including subscription adoption and direct learning purchases.

https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/1651562/000165156226000015/cour-20251231.htm

[5] Planet Fitness, Inc.

2025 Form 10-K. Describes membership, franchise and recurring revenue mechanics.

https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/1637207/000163720726000011/plnt-20251231.htm

[6] Meta for Business

Facebook and Instagram Reels ads guidance. Recommends mobile-first creative best practices and testing; placement outcomes vary by campaign and advertiser.

https://www.facebook.com/business/ads/facebook-instagram-reels-ads

METHOD & LIMITATIONS

Company facts are summarised from public disclosures. Social media strategy recommendations, funnels, KPI mappings, and example scenarios are independent analysis. This report does not claim access to private company campaigns, internal dashboards, or unpublished performance data. Model patterns are starting hypotheses and should be validated with client-specific research, local platform eligibility, legal requirements, and actual analytics. Illustrative scenarios are not forecasts.

THE STRATEGIST'S CLOSING NOTE

Fit the strategy to the business reality.

The strongest social media plan is not the one with the most activity. It is the one that connects customer understanding to a meaningful next action - and learns whether that action creates business value.

SIGNATURE



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Business model → customer decision → strategy → execution → measurement → learning